

difficult (especially if the tone of the collector is less than friendly), try to stay rational, because in most cases you will be able to negotiate a reasonable settlement.

If Beth had explained her situation, her creditor might have been able to work out a payment plan for her car loan that Beth could have handled. Maybe her loan term could have been extended, thereby lowering the monthly payment, or she could have searched for alternate financing with a lower interest rate. These and other options (discussed in chapter 4) were never given a chance since Beth never even got to step one, opening her mail.

Since Beth was solely responsible for her own finances, when she chose to ignore her situation there was no one there to step in and take control. In the next case, Anne also ignored her finances by turning over control to her husband.

My Husband Handles the Finances

I am constantly amazed at how many people prefer to remain ignorant about their financial situation. They leave it up to their spouse or another manager to make all their money decisions. Unfortunately, this dependence on others can have negative consequences, as in the case of a very unhappy young woman named Anne.

Anne married young and started a family immediately. Her husband Bob seemed to control every aspect of her life. Although her two children were now in school full time, she still remained at home. She told me that she wanted to get a job, but that her husband would not let her. She had no education past high school and no job skills to put on a resume.

Not only did she feel trapped by her perceived inability to get a job, but also by the fact that she wouldn't know how to manage money, even if she had some to manage. Anne, now twenty-five, had no idea what the family financial situation was

